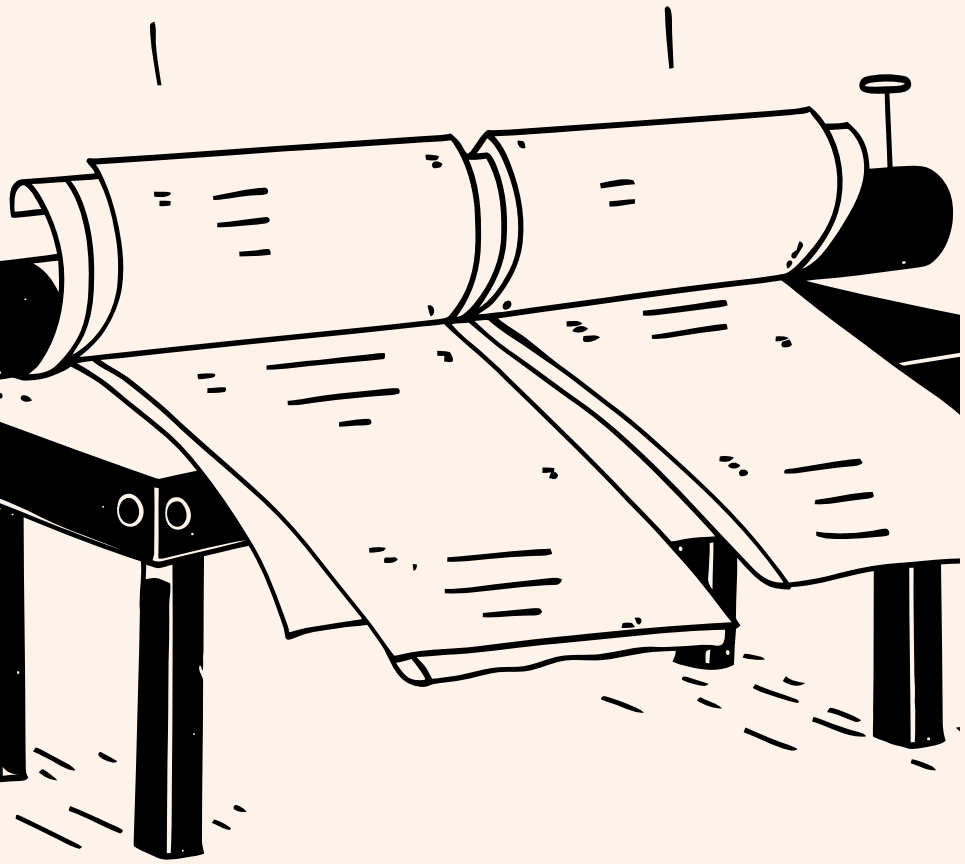


Pricing & Editioning

Part 2: Editioning

Unique Works vs. Editioned Works

1. Some mediums naturally tend toward unique objects:
   - Painting
   - Drawing
   - Collage
   - Ceramics
   - Many forms of sculpture

2. Other mediums make it possible for the same artwork to exist as multiple authorized objects:
   - Photography
   - Printmaking
   - Cast sculpture
   - Artist books
   - Audio Recordings
   - Video Art
   - Digital works

What Is an Edition?

An edition is a predetermined number of authorized copies of an artwork.

If you create an edition of 10 prints, the collector buying edition six out of ten is buying two things:

1. The physical print
2. Your promise that the edition will stay capped at the structure you set



Collectors need to know:

- How many numbered works exist
- Whether artist's proofs or other types of proofs exist
- Whether the work was produced in additional sizes
- Whether another edition of the image exists in another format/medium

You can't later decide:

"These sold really well. I think I'll make 20 more."

Some Useful Terminology

Unique Work

One authorized object.

Limited Edition

A predetermined maximum number of authorized examples.

Open Edition

No predetermined maximum number. You can continue producing them for as long as you have demand.

Medium Specific Terms

Monotype

A printmaking process generally used to produce one unique impression.

Monoprint

Uses a repeatable printmaking process, but individual impressions have some variation.

Photographic Edition

A photograph produced in a predetermined number of authorized prints, often with additional editions in different sizes.

Editioned Sculpture

Multiple authorized casts or fabricated versions of the same sculptural work.

Reproduction

A printed copy of an artwork originally created in another medium.

Poster

Usually an inexpensive reproduction designed for broad distribution rather than scarcity.

Unique Objects ➔ Reproductions



High Quality Reproductions Can Still Be Serious Art Objects

Reproduction doesn't have to mean:

- Cheap
- Poorly made
- Disposable
- Mass produced
- Unimportant

A reproduction can be:

- Printed on exceptional paper
- Produced under the artist's direct supervision
- Carefully color matched
- Limited to a predetermined edition
- Signed
- Numbered
- Accompanied by a certificate of authenticity

Poster is Not a Dirty Word

Posters can:

- Give people an affordable way to support you
- Promote exhibitions
- Get your work in more homes
- Reach younger collectors
- Provide an additional revenue stream
- Introduce someone to your work years before they can afford an original

You can distinguish them through:

- Different paper
- Different dimensions
- Different printing process
- Inclusion of white space and text
- Different cropping

Signing and Numbering Don't Create Value by Themselves

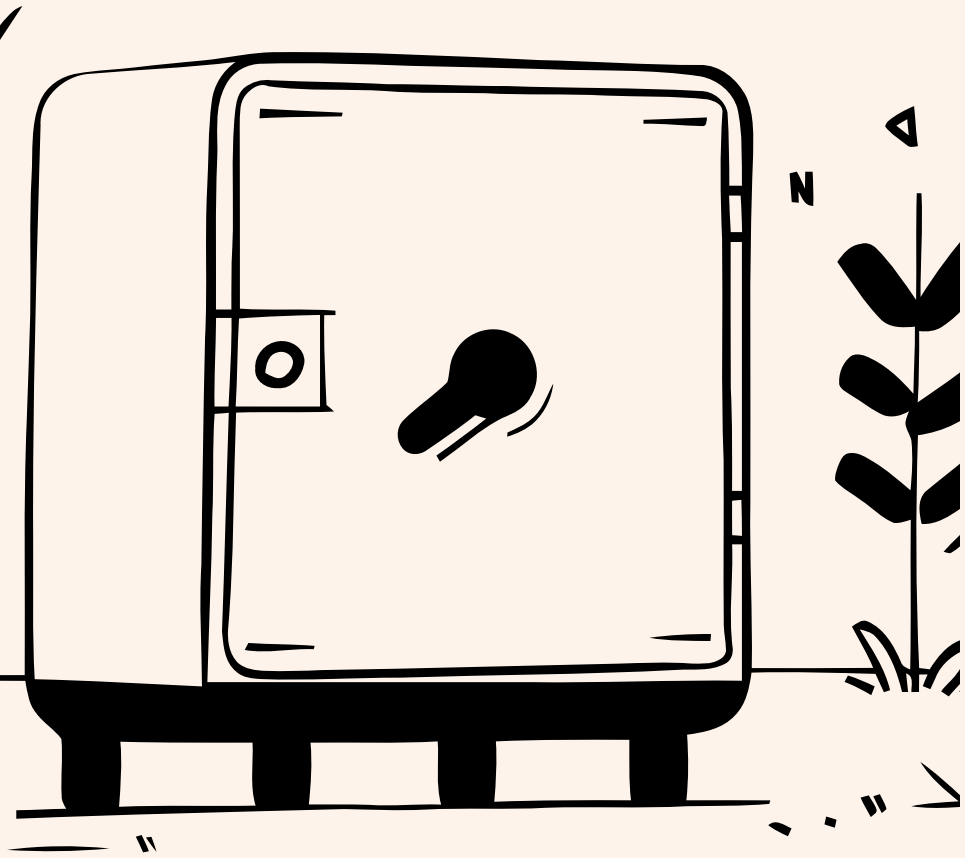
It doesn't tell us:

- How the object was produced
- How involved the artist was
- Whether the materials are high quality
- If this is the original artwork or a reproduction
- Whether the edition is scarce

Signing establishes the artist's authorization or participation.

Numbering establishes the promised edition size.

But neither one automatically establishes artistic or financial value.



Limited Editions vs Open Editions

A limited edition promises a capped supply. Scarcity is intended to increase value.

Open editions are the opposite. More accessible and more affordable.

Open Edition

For an open edition:

- There's no predetermined endpoint
- It may remain available for sale for years
- It can still use high-quality materials
- It can still be an artist-authorized object
- It may still be signed

Sample Price List:

- Unique painting – $3,500
- Unique drawing – $1,500
- Limited edition of 20 – $500–$750
- Open edition – $100–$300

The open edition lets someone participate in your practice that otherwise might not have been able to.

Choosing the Edition Size for a Limited Edition Work

There is no universally correct edition size. Each work asks its own questions.

Ask yourself:

- Am I actually likely to sell this many?
- How large is my actual collector base?
- Is scarcity important in the intended market?
- How expensive or intensive is the work to produce?
- Can the work be consistently reproduced?
- How difficult is it to store?
- Is this work intended as an accessible entry point or as an important piece within my practice?
- How much future demand can I reasonably anticipate?

Don't Make Every Edition Too Small Either

You're balancing scarcity today against potential demand tomorrow.

Smaller editions:

- Create stronger scarcity
- Can support higher pricing
- Sell out more quickly
- Leave less future inventory
- Limits you when demand grows

Larger editions:

- Create more opportunities for sales
- Usually require lower pricing
- Can serve more collectors
- May take years to sell through
- Create longer production and inventory obligations

Editions in Multiple Sizes

A photograph and some other mediums may be offered in multiple sizes:

3 large prints

40" x 50"

12 medium prints

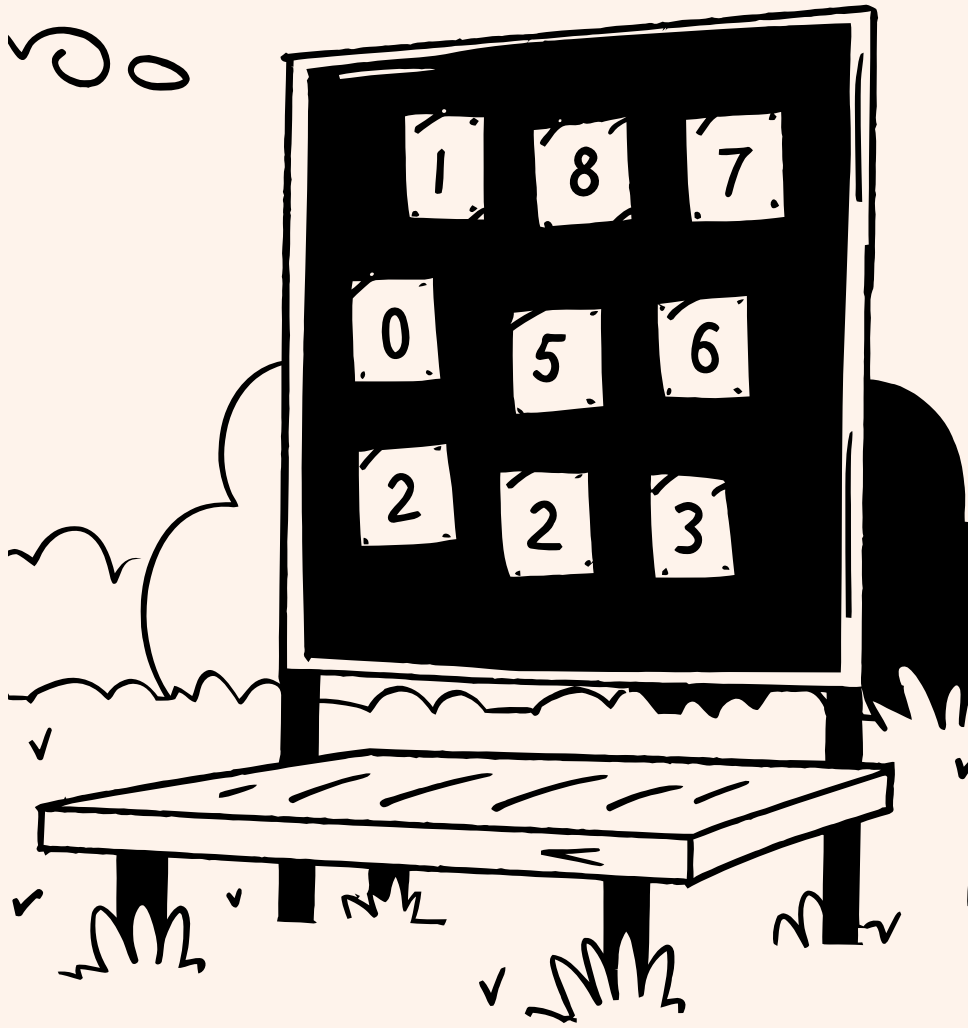
20" x 25"

25 small prints

12" x 15"

You need to think in terms of the total edition size across different physical sizes and formats.

How to Number



What does 3/10 mean?

The numbering system allows us to document the edition:

- Identify individual objects
- Track ownership
- Track sales
- Confirm the promised edition size

What it doesn't (necessarily) mean:

- It was printed earlier
- It was the third one to come out of the printer
- It's better than a later edition, such as 8/10

What does 7 + 2 AP mean?



What Is an Artist's Proof?

AP = Artist's Proof

That an edition is an AP does not automatically mean it's:

- Earlier
- Better
- More carefully printed
- Inherently more valuable

It simply has a different designation within the edition structure.

What Can You Do With Your Artist's Proofs?

- Keep them
- Exhibit them
- Lend them
- Donate them
- Gift them
- Reserve them for their estate
- And eventually even sell them

Gift to a collaborator:



Artistic partner



The person depicted



A model/performer



A printer or fabricator

Keep records of:

- The gifted work
- Correspondence about it
- Recipient information
- Edition Number
- Transfer documents or bill of sale
- Dates involved
- Any agreed restrictions or expectations

Artist Proofs No-Nos

1. You shouldn't sell Artist Proofs at the same time as the numbered edition.

2. You shouldn't make APs after an edition has begun selling or has sold-out. The number of APs must be established at the creation of the edition.

Rule of thumb: Usually no more than 10% of an edition should be proofs.

Additional Proof Vocabulary

Artist's Proof (AP)

An impression reserved for the artist. Usually materially equivalent to the numbered edition.

Printer's Proof (PP)

A complimentary proof given to the printer.

Bon à Tirer (BAT)

French for "good to pull." The artist-approved reference proof that subsequent editions should match.

Hors Commerce (HC)

Literally means "outside commerce." Not for sale and intended for non-commercial uses such as exhibitions or archives.

Trial Proof

An experimental impression produced on the way to the BAT while still working out color, paper, ink, pressure, and other choices.

State Proof

Expresses a particular stage in the development of the print. More specific to printing from actual plates.

Cancellation Proof

Documents the end of the edition and shows that the plates or matrix used to make the edition have been deliberately altered to prevent later editions.

The Bon à Tirer (BAT)

The BAT tells us, this is what the artwork is supposed to look like. It's the approved reference point for later prints/impressions.

A BAT becomes especially important when:

- Multiple inks are involved
- Color relationships have been finely tuned
- The edition is produced in batches, maybe even years apart
- Different people may print the work
- Working digitally — a photoshop file can't tell you everything you need to know

Producing the Edition All at Once

Producing the whole edition upfront also protects you from other changes outside your control.

Whereas, five years later:

- The paper may have been discontinued
- The physical machine may no longer exist
- The ink formulation may have changed
- Your preferred print shop may have closed
- Software and color profiles may not play together in the same way
- You may have forgotten exactly how you produced the work

It ensures:

- Consistent calibration (borders, trimming, finish)
- Consistent paper and ink
- Consistent details from a given person or machine (the small marks that are the result of a specific set of hands using a specific set of tools).

Disadvantaged to Producing All Editions Upfront

- Large upfront production cost
- Inventory that must be managed
- Storage and insurance needs
- Risk of flood, fire, pests, or other storage accidents
- Protected from careless hands
- Cash tied up in unsold inventory

A Hybrid Model

Print editions in batches rather than one at a time or all at once.

But, to do this well, you need to:

- Carefully document the entire workflow
- Reserve additional materials in advance (paper, ink, etc.)
- Create an artist-approved reference print to always compare new editions against
- Maintain steady access to the printers or machines used to make the first batch of editions.

Your documentation should include:

- Preserving the final production file and color profile used.
- Recording the printer and model.
- Purchasing extras of the exact paper and inks used that you set aside specifically for this edition.
- Taking careful notes on the dimensions, borders, mounting, and finish.

What Happens When an Edition is Fully Printed?

Historically, some printmakers and publishers physically marred the plates or matrix from which the edition was printed.

Depending on the medium this could mean:

- Defacing a lithographic stone
- Altering a screen for screen printing
- Cutting or marking a woodblock
- Scoring an etching plate

But there are legitimate reasons you might keep the source materials:

- Producing an authorized exhibition or reference copy
- Replacing a damaged edition under a clearly established replacement policy
- Allowing future conservators to understand how the work was originally made
- Preserving the artist's process for an archive or estate
- Conservation, research, and other museum needs

The integrity of a contemporary edition depends more today on record keeping and professional ethics, rather than on on physically destroying the means of production.

So, for contemporary editions, a better approach might be to preserve the production files or plates, but tightly control what they can be used for and to specifically create those policies around each edition.

Certificates of Authenticity (COA)

A certificate of authenticity is especially useful for editioned work because it helps identify which works are authentic and have been authorized by the artist or their estate.

A useful COA gives the:

- Artist Name
- Artwork Title
- Date it was created
- Medium, materials, and/or process
- Image dimensions and paper size
- Edition number and total edition size
- Type and number of proofs, if any
- Artist's signature

Editioning Has Legal Significance

When you start to market and sell a limited edition piece, you're making representations about:

- Edition size
- Proof count
- Artist authorization
- Processes used
- Whether previous editions exist
- Whether it's a reproduction of a unique work
- Whether the work was produced during the artist's lifetime

New York State's Arts and Cultural Affairs Law

Document Every Edition

In addition to what was on the COA, you should include:

- Artist Name
- Artwork Title
- Date it was created
- Medium, materials, and/or process
- Image dimensions and paper size
- Edition number and total edition size
- Type and number of proofs, if any
- Signature and numbering location
- Printer, publisher, or fabricator
- Paper, ink, and other materials used
- Framing or mounting
- Date sold
- Collector information
- Final price, and discounts if relevant
- Exhibition and loan history
- Condition and conservation/replacement history
- Transfers or resales that you learn about

Make sure you never give a collector the only copy of this information. You'll need it someday to authenticate your work.

Collector-Care Policy

Provide collectors with written instructions.

- Handling instructions
- Temperature and humidity guidance
- Installation instructions
- A contact process if it gets damaged
- Display recommendations for lighting
- Framing specifications
- Cleaning restrictions
- A policy statement that replacement isn't guaranteed

This does two things: it reduces the risk of damage. And it gives you a foundation for how to respond when issues do arise.

Damaged Works

When an editioned work gets damaged, there are several different things that can happen:

- ### Conservation

  Stabilizing or repairing the existing object without substantially changing it

- ### Restoration

  Trying to return the work to its original appearance

- ### Replacement

  Producing a new authorized impression to stand in for the damaged one

- ### Destruction

  The damaged work is surrendered or destroyed when the replacement is produced

A Replacement Policy might include:

1. Examining the damaged print
2. Deciding whether to try conservation first
3. Surrendering or documenting destruction of the original
4. Producing the replacement under the artist's supervision or having a policy for when the artist can't supervise it
5. Using the same edition number on the newly struck print
6. Creating a new COA linking the new print to the destroyed one
7. Covering production, shipping, and administrative costs

Cindy Sherman's Legacy Project



Ethical Questions Around Preserving the Historical Object

- What is lost when the original material object is destroyed?
- Isn't the faded or deteriorated original itself an important historical object?
- Is the replacement fundamentally the same artwork?
- If the replacement truly is the artwork, should it be identified as a replacement?
- Who gets to authorize replacements after the artist dies?
- Should an estate have the same authority as the living artist in these matters?
- Does the cost of replacement privilege wealthy collectors and institutions?

For your work you'll need to decide:

- Will you preserve the source material after the edition is complete? And who will you give permission to retain copies of those?
- Can they be used to replace a damaged edition? And under what circumstances can a replacement be made?
- Must the damaged original be surrendered or destroyed first?
- Who has the authority to make these decisions once you're no longer able to?

Editioning Is a Promise About the Future

Before beginning an edition, you need to decide:

- What printing processes will you use?
- Will the image appear at multiple sizes?
- How many editions do you think best serve the piece and fit your market?
- Will there be APs or other proofs?
- Will the work appear in other formats (posters, reproductions, etc.)?
- Will you produce the entire edition upfront, one at a time, or in batches?
- How will you document the edition and what will act as your artist-approved reference so later prints stay consistent?
- What information will you put on the COA and what documents accompany the work?
- What happens when the edition sells out?
- What happens if one of the numbered editions is damaged and needs to be replaced?
- Who has authority to produce, replace, authenticate, or manage the edition after your death?